

Evidence-based toddler behavior management guide with specific response scripts — Action Checklist

PRINT THIS PAGE AND KEEP IT SOMEWHERE VISIBLE

UNDERSTAND YOUR TODDLER'S BRAIN

- ☐ **Recognize that your toddler's aggression is reactive, not intentional - their prefrontal cortex is only 5% developed, so they literally cannot control impulses before acting.:** Recognize that your toddler's aggression is reactive, not intentional - their prefrontal cortex is only 5% developed, so they literally cannot control impulses before acting.
- ☐ **Stop asking 'why did you do that?' because your toddler genuinely doesn't know the answer - their brain didn't give them a 'why' option before the behavior happened.:** Stop asking 'why did you do that?' because your toddler genuinely doesn't know the answer - their brain didn't give them a 'why' option before the behavior happened.
- ☐ **Replace 'no hitting' commands with positive behavior statements like 'Hands are gentle' because toddlers process the word 'hitting' more than the negation in the command.:** Replace 'no hitting' commands with positive behavior statements like 'Hands are gentle' because toddlers process the word 'hitting' more than the negation in the command.
- ☐ **Remember that your toddler isn't giving you a hard time - they are having a hard time, which means the aggression is neurological rather than personal and nothing you caused.:** Remember that your toddler isn't giving you a hard time - they are having a hard time, which means the aggression is neurological rather than personal and nothing you caused.

USE POSITIVE LANGUAGE SCRIPTS

- ☐ **Practice saying 'Hands are gentle' instead of 'no hitting' so your toddler's brain holds the correct neural image of the desired behavior.:** Practice saying 'Hands are gentle' instead of 'no hitting' so your toddler's brain holds the correct neural image of the desired behavior.
- ☐ **Use a protection script when physically unsafe:** 'I have to protect my body. You know I love you, but if you keep kicking me, I will move away.'

- ☐ **Name the feeling before correcting behavior by saying 'I see you're really frustrated that we can't have more banana - that's a big feeling.':** Name the feeling before correcting behavior by saying 'I see you're really frustrated that we can't have more banana - that's a big feeling.'
- ☐ **Practice your scripts in the mirror before a meltdown happens so the words feel natural when chaos arrives at 7 AM.:** Practice your scripts in the mirror before a meltdown happens so the words feel natural when chaos arrives at 7 AM.

STAY STEADY AND GET SUPPORT

- ☐ **Identify your personal emotional triggers and prepare a calming strategy because children mirror nervous system regulation they observe from you.:** Identify your personal emotional triggers and prepare a calming strategy because children mirror nervous system regulation they observe from you.
- ☐ **Seek out Parent Child Interactive Therapy or a similar evidence-based program because specialized support gives you trained feedback and concrete techniques.:** Seek out Parent Child Interactive Therapy or a similar evidence-based program because specialized support gives you trained feedback and concrete techniques.
- ☐ **Bookmark four core scripts you can reference quickly because having language ready prevents fumbling during high-stress moments with an aggressive toddler.:** Bookmark four core scripts you can reference quickly because having language ready prevents fumbling during high-stress moments with an aggressive toddler.
- ☐ **Accept that staying calm doesn't mean being perfect - it means your toddler learns that big feelings don't have to end in aggression by watching you model it.:** Accept that staying calm doesn't mean being perfect - it means your toddler learns that big feelings don't have to end in aggression by watching you model it.

Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.